# Derek Johnston *Lead Full Stack Developer*

Derek@Derekjohnston.ca
derekjohnston.ca
Durham Region, Ontario, Canada
+1 (905) 926-8279
linkedin.com/in/derekjjohnston



I'm a Lead Full Stack Developer with over nine years of experience building web and mobile applications, from a near real-time data collection system at E-Data Now! to leading the frontend and backend teams behind YHP's Wonderlab event platform. In 2020 I founded Johnston Software Development Inc., where I design, build and modernize web and mobile apps for clients, most recently an ongoing platform modernization for a luxury watch subscription club. I work across the stack with Vue and Nuxt, React and Next.js, Node.js, TypeScript and Flutter, and I enjoy mentoring developers and leading teams.

## Professional Experience

**Founder & Lead Full Stack Developer,** *JSD* Oct 2023 – present

**Technologies:** TypeScript, Express.js, Flutter, iOS, React.js, PHP, Next.js, Docker Products, SASS, Redux.js, Vue.js, Node.js, Android, Nuxt.js, JavaScript, Amazon Web Services (AWS), Git, Java, Python, SQL, Tailwind CSS, MySQL

- **Membership Platform Modernization (June 2026 - present):** Ongoing engineering partnership with a luxury watch subscription club, modernizing their admin platform and building new member experiences, from event tooling to a weekly sports pick'em game, with Next.js, React, TypeScript, Tailwind CSS, MySQL and PHP, tested with Playwright and Vitest.
- **Who's Jimmy Project:** Revising and upgrading the tech stack for the 'Who's Jimmy' project, enhancing its functionality and performance. Planning to add a new section featuring teaching videos that showcase James Gawley's extensive experience in the film industry, highlighting his expertise and craftsmanship.
- **Frontend UI/UX Enhancement Project:** Collaborated with team to enhance frontend UI/UX of an existing web application using ReactJS and Tailwind CSS, resulting in improved user engagement metrics.
- **Mobile-First Web App Prototype Development:** Built a mobile-first web application prototype using NextJS, showcasing key features and functionalities within a tight deadline.
- **Responsive Web Design Optimization Sprint:** Optimized responsive design of client's website using Bootstrap and CSS Grid, ensuring consistent user experience across desktop and mobile devices.
- **Nuxt 2 to Nuxt 3 Upgrade Project:** Upgraded client's web app from Nuxt 2 to Nuxt 3, leveraging Vue 3 Composition API, optimizing SSR performance, and integrating TypeScript.
- **Additional Projects:** Developed tailored e-commerce platforms, mobile applications, and customized software solutions, effectively enhancing clients' online footprint and operational efficiencies.

**Lead Full Stack Developer,** *YHP* May 2021 – Sep 2023

**Technologies:** Microsoft Azure, TypeScript, Express.js, React.js, GatsbyJS, PHP, Next.js, Docker Products, SASS, Redux.js, Leadership, Node.js, Git, JavaScript, Amazon Web Services (AWS), Symfony Framework, Tailwind CSS

- Implemented agile methodologies to accelerate the delivery of high-quality software, enhancing project efficiency, fostering a culture of continuous improvement through regular sprint reviews and retrospectives, and enabling agile adaptation to evolving client requirements.
- Mentored junior developers and conducted thorough code reviews, fostering skill development and ensuring adherence to best practices in software development and project management.
- Created a collaborative and innovative environment, steering the team toward achieving ambitious goals, which resulted in robust and versatile projects that added significant value to the company.
- Led comprehensive staff performance reviews, managed full-cycle recruitment, and facilitated smooth employee transitions, thereby maintaining team morale and continuity.
- Developed and maintained various game websites using diverse technology stacks to enhance functionality and user experience, while also creating dynamic and responsive admin controllers. These contributions supported operational efficiency across multiple projects and teams within the organization.

- **Main Product Wonderlab:** As the lead developer for Wonderlab, I spearheaded the white-labeling of the event platform, significantly reducing the setup costs for new live events. This strategic move allowed clients to customize the platform to their specific branding and event needs without incurring extensive development costs, making our solution both cost-effective and highly adaptable.
- I directed multiple cross-functional teams to develop a suite of gamified SaaS products, including:
  - **HR Onboarding System:** Led the creation of an engaging and interactive HR onboarding system designed to streamline the employee induction process. This system incorporated gamified elements to enhance user engagement and retention, ensuring new hires had a memorable and effective onboarding experience.
  - **Comprehensive Event Platform:** Developed a versatile event platform supporting online and in-person events. Features included real-time chat, live streaming, and virtual networking rooms, allowing seamless transitions between virtual and physical event components, and catering to various event types and sizes.
  - **Administrative Hub Application:** Oversaw the development of an administrative hub that served as the control center for all event management activities. This application offered real-time analytics, user management, and content control features, empowering administrators to efficiently manage events and make data-driven decisions. The admin hub was designed with a user-friendly interface, ensuring even those with minimal technical expertise could navigate and utilize its full capabilities.

**Freelance Full Stack Developer,** *JSD* Dec 2019 – May 2021

**Technologies:** TypeScript, Express.js, Flutter, iOS, React.js, PHP, Next.js, Docker Products, SASS, Redux.js, Leadership, Vue.js, Node.js, Android, Nuxt.js, JavaScript, Amazon Web Services (AWS), Git, Java

- Created a Java Android application to replace an existing Cordova app for a shipping company. This improved performance and reliability, seamlessly integrating with the existing backend to enhance operational efficiency.
- **Tackle Hunger:** Developed a map component to display food banks and their needs across North America, providing a critical tool for resource allocation and community support.
- **Who's Jimmy:** Ongoing development of a professional portfolio for a skilled film craftsman and clock-smith using VueJS/NuxtJS and PHP, effectively showcasing his work and enhancing his professional visibility.
- **Additional Projects:** Delivered tailored e-commerce websites, mobile apps, and custom software solutions, significantly enhancing clients' digital presence and operational capabilities.

**Software Developer,** *E-data Now!* Apr 2018 – Sep 2019

**Technologies:** Flutter, iOS, SASS, Ruby on Rails, Vue.js, Android, Nuxt.js, JavaScript, Amazon Web Services (AWS), Java, Git, PostgreSQL

- Developed frontend and backend code for a near real-time data collection system for inspection and auditing in the automotive industry.
- Maintained test plans and test cases, wrote automated and load tests.
- Enhanced dashboard functionality, added rearrangeable/drag and drop capabilities, and improved accessibility to meet Canadian standards.
- Created Gatling scripts to simulate heavy real-world load, led performance improvement initiatives, and optimized slow API calls using Scout APM.
- Resolved issues in iOS and Flutter codebases, improving performance and UX.
- Secured a field placement, demonstrating exceptional performance that led to an offer for full-time employment.

**Software Engineer,** *Oiika* May 2017 – Apr 2019

**Technologies:** TypeScript, Express.js, React.js, ReactNative, SASS, Git, Node.js, JavaScript, Tailwind CSS

- Collaborated closely with a small team to design and develop an online platform using modern web technologies such as TypeScript, Express.js, and React.js.
- Played a key role in implementing responsive and dynamic user interfaces with ReactNative and Tailwind CSS, enhancing the platform's overall user experience.
- Optimized backend functionality using Node.js and Express.js, ensuring efficient data handling and API performance.
- Contributed to the development of a flexible and maintainable codebase by leveraging SASS and Git for version control, improving the team's workflow and code quality.
- Actively participated in the testing and debugging process, helping to identify and resolve issues early, which improved the stability of the platform.

## Volunteer Experience

**Event Leader,** *Virtual Coffee* Mar 2024 – present

**Room Leader,** *Virtual Coffee* Nov 2023 – present

**Community member,** *Virtual Coffee* Mar 2023 – present

**Frontend Developer,** *Crown International* Apr 2020 – May 2020

I volunteered at Crown International, where I developed the user profile page. This project involved creating an intuitive interface for managing user information and customizing profiles.

**Hackathon Lead,** *Mintbean* Mar 2020 – Sep 2020

I volunteered at Mintbean, where I organized and ran hackathons. My role involved coordinating events, mentoring participants, and fostering a collaborative environment for developers to innovate and learn.

## Education

**Computer Programmer Analyst,** *Durham College* 2018

I hold a three-year advanced diploma in Computer Programmer Analyst, with my final project focusing on leading a partnership to develop a mobile communication application for verbally limited individuals.

## Languages

English (native), French (actively learning)

## References

"*Derek Johnston is recommended as a good candidate for future employment. ... He worked as a Lead, Full Stack Developer ... oversaw both front-end and back-end development teams. Derek was autonomous ... and always willing to help ... He excels at creating and maintaining strong internal relationships ... We can recommend Derek for future employment, as he demonstrates strong technical skills ...*"

Jérémy Ferland, CTO at YHP

"*I taught Derek ... in Durham College's Computer Programmer Analyst program ... Derek's biggest strengths are ... his work ethic and time management ... Derek knows how to take advantage of opportunities ... and how to approach and relate to people. Derek is a strong communicator ... great ... for working to meet clients' needs.*"

Kyle Chapman, Full-Time Faculty at Durham College

"*Derek was a pivotal member of our team at E-Data Now! ... his work ... showcased his technical expertise and attention to detail. ... His proactive problem-solving and dedication to continuous improvement were invaluable assets. At YHP, Derek took on the role of Lead Full-stack Developer ... Derek's ability to mentor junior developers and foster a collaborative environment ... underscored his value as a leader and skilled developer.*"

Lee Kichko, CTO at E-Data Now! (Phoenix Quality)